

ANTITANK ARTILLERY

The rapid development of the tank during World War I spurred a parallel development in antitank weapons. Most of the designs from before World War II were of small caliber and used a solid projectile fired at high velocity to smash through a tank's defensive armor. In the years leading up to World War II, tank armor became thicker, prompting the need for larger caliber weapons, often using explosive rounds, to counter it. It was not uncommon for weapons designed for other purposes to be used as antitank weapons, the German Flak 36 being an example used in the first years of World War II.



▲ PAK 36 ANTITANK GUN

Date 1934

Origin Germany

Length (Excluding carriage)
11ft (3.4m)

Caliber 37mm

Armor penetration 1½in
(38mm) at 400 yards (365m)

Designed for warfare in the 1930s, the light PAK 36 was obsolete by 1940. It was nicknamed the “door knocker” for the way its shells bounced off the armor of Allied tanks.



► ZIS-3 M1942 FIELD/ ANTITANK GUN

Date 1942

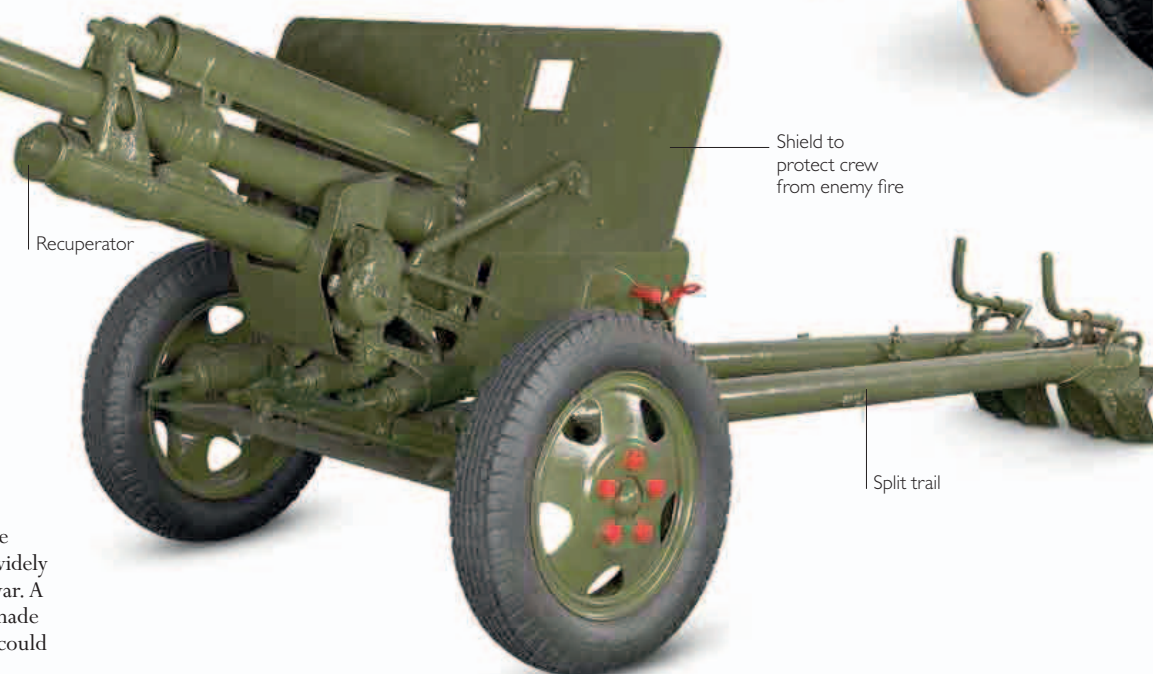
Origin Soviet Union

Length (Excluding carriage)
20ft (6.1m)

Caliber 76.2mm

Armor penetration 3¾in
(98mm) at 545 yards (500m)

Although designed as a divisional field gun, the M1942 could also destroy armor with high-explosive and armor-piercing rounds. The gun's recuperator helped its barrel to return to the firing position after recoil.



▼ 6-POUNDER ANTITANK GUN

Date 1943

Origin UK

Length (Excluding carriage)
15¾ft (4.8m)

Caliber 57mm

Armor penetration 3in (80mm) at
1,000 yards (915m)

The 6-pounder Antitank Gun replaced the ineffective 2-pounder in 1942. It was widely used in all theaters of the war. A version (shown here) was made with jointed trail legs so it could be carried in an aircraft.

